(continued)

As can be seen here, Gherkin requirements are expressed in plain English, but with a specific structure. Each *scenario* is made up of a number of *steps*, where each step starts with one of a small number of keywords (*Given*, *When*, *Then*, *And*, and *But*).

The natural order of a scenario is *Given ... When ... Then*:

- *Given* describes the preconditions for the scenario and prepares the test environment.
- *When* describes the action under test.
- *Then* describes the expected outcomes.

The *And* and *But* keywords can be used to join several *Given*, *When*, or *Then* steps together in a more readable way:

```
Given I have a current account with $1000
And I have a savings account with $2000
```

Several related scenarios can often be grouped into a single scenario using a table of examples. For example, the following scenario illustrates how interest is calculated on different types of accounts:

```
Scenario Outline: Earning interest
  Given I have an account of type <account-type> with a balance of
     <initial-balance>
  When the monthly interest is calculated
  Then I should have earned at an annual interest rate of <interest-rate>
  And I should have a new balance of <new-balance>
  Examples:
  | initial-balance | account-type | interest-rate | new-balance
  | 10000           | current      | 1             | 10008.33
  | 10000           | savings      | 3             | 10025
  | 10000           | supersaver   | 5             | 10041.67
```

This scenario would be run three times in all, once for each row in the Examples table. The values in each row are inserted into the placeholder variables, which are indicated by the `<...>` notation (`<account-type>`, `<initial-balance>`, and so forth). This not only saves typing, but also makes it easier to understand the whole requirement at a glance.

You can also use the following tabular notation within the steps themselves in order to display test data more concisely. For example, the previous money-transfer scenario could have been written like this:

```
Scenario: Transferring money between accounts within the bank
  Given I have the following accounts:
    | account | balance |
    | current | 1000    |
    | savings | 2000    |
  When I transfer 500.00 from current to savings
  Then my accounts should look like this:
    | account | balance |
    | current | 500     |
    | savings | 2500    |
```

We'll look at this notation in much more detail in chapter 5.